24 Jer · Jeremiah

1 These are the words of Jeremiah son of Hilkiah, one of the priests in
Anathoth in the territory of Benjamin. [2] The word of the LORD came to
Jeremiah in the thirteenth year of the reign of Josiah son of Amon king of Judah,
[3] and through the days of Jehoiakim son of Josiah king of Judah, until the fifth
month of the eleventh year of Zedekiah son of Josiah king of Judah, when the
people of Jerusalem went into exile. [4] The word of the LORD came to me, saying:
[5] "Before I formed you in the womb I knew you, and before you were born I set
you apart and appointed you as a prophet to the nations." [6] "Ah, Lord GOD," I
said, "I surely do not know how to speak, for I am only a child!" [7] But the LORD
told me: "Do not say, 'I am only a child.' For to everyone I send you, you must
go, and all that I command you, you must speak." [8] "Do not be afraid of them,
for I am with you to deliver you," declares the LORD.

[9] Then the LORD reached out His hand, touched my mouth, and said to
me: "Behold, I have put My words in your mouth." [10] "See, I have appointed
you today over nations and kingdoms to uproot and tear down, to destroy and
overthrow, to build and plant." [11] And the word of the LORD came to me,
asking, "Jeremiah, what do you see?" "I see a branch of an almond tree," I replied.
[12] "You have observed correctly," said the LORD, "for I am watching over My
word to accomplish it." [13] Again the word of the LORD came to me, asking,
"What do you see?" "I see a boiling pot," I replied, "and it is tilting toward us
from the north." [14] Then the LORD said to me, "Disaster from the north will
be poured out on all who live in the land." [15] "For I am about to summon all the
clans and kingdoms of the north," declares the LORD. "Their kings will come
and set up their thrones at the entrance of the gates of Jerusalem. They will attack
all her surrounding walls and all the other cities of Judah." [16] I will pronounce
My judgments against them for all their wickedness, because they have forsaken
Me to burn incense to other gods and to worship the works of their own hands.
[17] Get yourself ready. Stand up and tell them everything that I command you. Do
not be intimidated by them, or I will terrify you before them. [18] Now behold, this
day I have made you like a fortified city, an iron pillar, and bronze walls against
the whole land—against the kings of Judah, its officials, its priests, and the people
of the land. [19] "They will fight against you but will never overcome you, since I
am with you to deliver you," declares the LORD.

2 Now the word of the LORD came to me, saying, [2] "Go and proclaim
in the hearing of Jerusalem that this is what the LORD says: 'I remember the
devotion of your youth, your love as a bride, how you followed Me in the
wilderness, in a land not sown.'" [3] "Israel was holy to the LORD, the firstfruits
of His harvest. All who devoured her found themselves guilty; disaster came
upon them,'" declares the LORD. [4] Hear the word of the LORD, O house of
Jacob, and all you families of the house of Israel. [5] This is what the LORD says:
"What fault did your fathers find in Me that they strayed so far from Me, and
followed worthless idols, and became worthless themselves?" [6] They did not ask,
'Where is the LORD who brought us up from the land of Egypt, who led us
through the wilderness, through a land of deserts and pits, a land of drought and
darkness, a land where no one travels and no one lives?' [7] I brought you into a
fertile land to eat its fruit and bounty, but you came and defiled My land, and
made My inheritance detestable. [8] The priests did not ask, 'Where is the LORD?'
The experts in the law no longer knew Me, and the leaders rebelled against Me.
The prophets prophesied by Baal and followed useless idols. [9] Therefore, I will
contend with you again, declares the LORD, and I will bring a case against your
children's children. [10] Cross over to the coasts of Cyprus and take a look; send to
Kedar and consider carefully; see if there has ever been anything like this: [11] Has a
nation ever changed its gods, though they are no gods at all? Yet My people have
exchanged their Glory for useless idols.

[12] "Be stunned by this, O heavens; be shocked and utterly appalled," declares
the LORD. [13] "For My people have committed two evils: They have forsaken
Me, the fountain of living water, and they have dug their own cisterns— broken
cisterns that cannot hold water." [14] Is Israel a slave? Was he born into slavery?
Why then has he become prey? [15] The young lions have roared at him; they have
growled with a loud voice. They have laid waste his land; his cities lie in ruins,
without inhabitant.

[16] The men of Memphis and Tahpanhes have shaved the crown of your head.
[17] Have you not brought this on yourself by forsaking the LORD your God
when He led you in the way? [18] Now what will you gain on your way to Egypt
to drink the waters of the Nile? What will you gain on your way to Assyria to
drink the waters of the Euphrates? [19] "Your own evil will discipline you; your
own apostasies will reprimand you. Consider and realize how evil and bitter it
is for you to forsake the LORD your God and to have no fear of Me," declares
the Lord GOD of Hosts. [20] "For long ago you broke your yoke and tore off
your chains, saying, 'I will not serve!' Indeed, on every high hill and under every
green tree you lay down as a prostitute." [21] I had planted you like a choice vine
from the very best seed. How could you turn yourself before Me into a rotten,
wild vine? [22] "Although you wash with lye and use an abundance of soap, the
stain of your guilt is still before Me," declares the Lord GOD. [23] "How can you
say, 'I am not defiled; I have not run after the Baals'? Look at your behavior in
the valley; acknowledge what you have done. You are a swift young she-camel
galloping here and there," [24] a wild donkey at home in the wilderness, sniffing
the wind in the heat of her desire. Who can restrain her passion? All who seek
her need not weary themselves; in mating season they will find her. [25] You should
have kept your feet from going bare and your throat from being thirsty. But you
said, 'It is hopeless! For I love foreign gods, and I must go after them.' [26] As the
thief is ashamed when he is caught, so the house of Israel is disgraced. They, their
kings, their officials, their priests, and their prophets [27] say to a tree, 'You are my
father,' and to a stone, 'You gave me birth.' For they have turned their backs to
Me and not their faces, yet in the time of trouble they beg, 'Rise up and save us!'
[28] But where are the gods you made for yourselves? Let them rise up in your time
of trouble and save you if they can; for your gods are as numerous as your cities,
O Judah. [29] "Why do you bring a case against Me? You have all rebelled against
Me," declares the LORD. [30] "I have struck your sons in vain; they accepted no
discipline. Your own sword has devoured your prophets like a voracious lion."
[31] You people of this generation, consider the word of the LORD: "Have I been
a wilderness to Israel or a land of dense darkness? Why do My people say, 'We
are free to roam; we will come to You no more'?" [32] Does a maiden forget her
jewelry or a bride her wedding sash? Yet My people have forgotten Me for days
without number. [33] How skillfully you pursue love! Even the most immoral of
women could learn from your ways. [34] Moreover, your skirts are stained with
the blood of the innocent poor, though you did not find them breaking in. But
in spite of all these things [35] you say, 'I am innocent. Surely His anger will turn
from me.' Behold, I will judge you, because you say, 'I have not sinned.' [36] How
unstable you are, constantly changing your ways! You will be disappointed by
Egypt just as you were by Assyria. [37] "Moreover, you will leave that place with
your hands on your head, for the LORD has rejected those you trust; you will
not prosper by their help."

3 "If a man divorces his wife and she leaves him to marry another, can he
ever return to her? Would not such a land be completely defiled? But you have
played the harlot with many lovers— and you would return to Me?" declares
the LORD. [2] "Lift up your eyes to the barren heights and see. Is there any
place where you have not been violated? You sat beside the highways waiting
for your lovers, like a nomad in the desert. You have defiled the land with your
prostitution and wickedness." [3] Therefore the showers have been withheld, and
no spring rains have fallen. Yet you have the brazen look of a prostitute; you refuse
to be ashamed. [4] Have you not just called to Me, 'My Father, You are my friend
from youth.' [5] "Will He be angry forever? Will He be indignant to the end?' This
you have spoken, but you keep doing all the evil you can." [6] Now in the days
of King Josiah, the LORD said to me, "Have you seen what faithless Israel has
done? She has gone up on every high hill and under every green tree to prostitute
herself there." [7] I thought that after she had done all these things, she would
return to Me. But she did not return, and her unfaithful sister Judah saw it.

[8] She saw that because faithless Israel had committed adultery, I gave her a
certificate of divorce and sent her away. Yet that unfaithful sister Judah had no
fear and prostituted herself as well. [9] Indifferent to her own infidelity, Israel had
defiled the land and committed adultery with stones and trees. [10] "Yet in spite of
all this, her unfaithful sister Judah did not return to Me with all her heart, but
only in pretense," declares the LORD. [11] And the LORD said to me, "Faithless
Israel has shown herself more righteous than unfaithful Judah."

[12] Go, proclaim this message toward the north: 'Return, O faithless Israel,'
declares the LORD. 'I will no longer look on you with anger, for I am merciful,'
declares the LORD. 'I will not be angry forever.' [13] "Only acknowledge your
guilt, that you have rebelled against the LORD your God. You have scattered
your favors to foreign gods under every green tree and have not obeyed My
voice,'" declares the LORD. [14] "Return, O faithless children," declares the
LORD, "for I am your master, and I will take you—one from a city and two
from a family—and bring you to Zion." [15] "Then I will give you shepherds after
My own heart, who will feed you with knowledge and understanding."

[16] "In those days, when you multiply and increase in the land," declares the
LORD, "they will no longer discuss the ark of the covenant of the LORD. It will
never come to mind, and no one will remember it or miss it, nor will another
one be made." [17] At that time Jerusalem will be called The Throne of the LORD,
and all the nations will be gathered in Jerusalem to honor the name of the
LORD. They will no longer follow the stubbornness of their evil hearts. [18] In
those days the house of Judah will walk with the house of Israel, and they will
come together from the land of the north to the land that I gave to your fathers
as an inheritance. [19] Then I said, 'How I long to make you My sons and give
you a desirable land, the most beautiful inheritance of all the nations!' I thought
you would call Me 'Father' and never turn away from following Me. [20] "But as
a woman may betray her husband, so you have betrayed Me, O house of Israel,"
declares the LORD. [21] A voice is heard on the barren heights, the children of
Israel weeping and begging for mercy, because they have perverted their ways
and forgotten the LORD their God. [22] "Return, O faithless children, and I will
heal your faithlessness." "Here we are. We come to You, for You are the LORD
our God." [23] Surely deception comes from the hills, and commotion from the
mountains. Surely the salvation of Israel is in the LORD our God. [24] From our
youth, that shameful god has consumed what our fathers have worked for— their
flocks and herds, their sons and daughters. [25] "Let us lie down in our shame; let

our disgrace cover us. We have sinned against the LORD our God, both we and our fathers; from our youth even to this day we have not obeyed the voice of the LORD our God."

4 "If you will return, O Israel, return to Me," declares the LORD. "If you will remove your detestable idols from My sight and no longer waver," [2] "and if you can swear, 'As surely as the LORD lives,' in truth, in justice, and in righteousness, then the nations will be blessed by Him, and in Him they will glory." [3] For this is what the LORD says to the men of Judah and Jerusalem: "Break up your unplowed ground, and do not sow among the thorns." [4] "Circumcise yourselves to the LORD, and remove the foreskins of your hearts, O men of Judah and people of Jerusalem. Otherwise, My wrath will break out like fire and burn with no one to extinguish it, because of your evil deeds." [5] Announce in Judah, proclaim in Jerusalem, and say: "Blow the ram's horn throughout the land. Cry aloud and say, 'Assemble yourselves and let us flee to the fortified cities.'" [6] Raise a signal flag toward Zion. Seek refuge! Do not delay! For I am bringing disaster from the north, and terrible destruction. [7] A lion has gone up from his thicket, and a destroyer of nations has set out. He has left his lair to lay waste your land. Your cities will be reduced to ruins and lie uninhabited. [8] "So put on sackcloth, mourn and wail, for the fierce anger of the LORD has not turned away from us." [9] "In that day," declares the LORD, "the king and officials will lose their courage. The priests will tremble in fear, and the prophets will be astounded."

[10] Then I said, "Ah, Lord GOD, how completely You have deceived this people and Jerusalem by saying, 'You will have peace,' while a sword is at our throats." [11] At that time it will be said to this people and to Jerusalem, "A searing wind from the barren heights in the desert blows toward the daughter of My people, but not to winnow or to sift;" [12] "a wind too strong for that comes from Me. Now I also pronounce judgments against them."

[13] Behold, he advances like the clouds, his chariots like the whirlwind. His horses are swifter than eagles. Woe to us, for we are ruined! [14] Wash the evil from your heart, O Jerusalem, so that you may be saved. How long will you harbor wicked thoughts within you? [15] For a voice resounds from Dan, proclaiming disaster from the hills of Ephraim. [16] Warn the nations now! Proclaim to Jerusalem: "A besieging army comes from a distant land; they raise their voices against the cities of Judah." [17] "They surround her like men guarding a field, because she has rebelled against Me," declares the LORD. [18] "Your ways and deeds have brought this upon you. This is your punishment; how bitter it is, because it pierces to the heart!" [19] My anguish, my anguish! I writhe in pain! Oh, the pain in my chest! My heart pounds within me; I cannot be silent. For I have heard the sound of the horn, the alarm of battle.

[20] Disaster after disaster is proclaimed, for the whole land is laid waste. My tents are destroyed in an instant, my curtains in a moment. [21] How long must I see the signal flag and hear the sound of the horn? [22] "For My people are fools; they have not known Me. They are foolish children, without understanding. They are skilled in doing evil, but they know not how to do good." [23] I looked at the earth, and it was formless and void; I looked to the heavens, and they had no light. [24] I looked at the mountains, and behold, they were quaking; all the hills were swaying. [25] I looked, and no man was left; all the birds of the air had fled. [26] I looked, and the fruitful land was a desert. All its cities were torn down before the LORD, before His fierce anger. [27] For this is what the LORD says: "The whole land will be desolate, but I will not finish its destruction." [28] "Therefore the earth will mourn and the heavens above will grow dark. I have spoken, I have planned, and I will not relent or turn back." [29] Every city flees at the sound of the horseman and archer. They enter the thickets and climb among the rocks. Every city is abandoned; no inhabitant is left. [30] And you, O devastated one, what will you do, though you dress yourself in scarlet, though you adorn yourself with gold jewelry, though you enlarge your eyes with paint? You adorn yourself in vain; your lovers despise you; they want to take your life. [31] For I hear a cry like a woman in labor, a cry of anguish like one bearing her first child— the cry of the Daughter of Zion gasping for breath, stretching out her hands to say, "Woe is me, for my soul faints before the murderers!"

5 "Go up and down the streets of Jerusalem. Look now and take note; search her squares. If you can find a single person, anyone who acts justly, anyone who seeks the truth, then I will forgive the city." [2] "Although they say, 'As surely as the LORD lives,' they are swearing falsely." [3] O LORD, do not Your eyes look for truth? You struck them, but they felt no pain. You finished them off, but they refused to accept discipline. They have made their faces harder than stone and refused to repent. [4] Then I said, "They are only the poor; they have played the fool, for they do not know the way of the LORD, the justice of their God." [5] "I will go to the powerful and speak to them. Surely they know the way of the LORD, the justice of their God." But they too, with one accord, had broken the yoke and torn off the chains. [6] Therefore a lion from the forest will strike them down, a wolf from the desert will ravage them. A leopard will lie in wait near their cities, and everyone who ventures out will be torn to pieces. For their rebellious acts are many, and their unfaithful deeds are numerous. [7] "Why should I forgive you? Your children have forsaken Me and sworn by gods that are not gods. I satisfied their needs, yet they committed adultery and assembled at the houses of prostitutes." [8] They are well-fed, lusty stallions, each neighing after his neighbor's wife. [9] "Should I not punish them for these things?" declares the LORD. "Should I not avenge Myself on such a nation as this?"

[10] Go up through her vineyards and ravage them, but do not finish them off. Strip off her branches, for they do not belong to the LORD. [11] "For the house of Israel and the house of Judah have been utterly unfaithful to Me," declares the LORD. [12] They have lied about the LORD and said: "He will not do anything; harm will not come to us; we will not see sword or famine." [13] "The prophets are but wind, for the word is not in them. So let their own predictions befall them." [14] Therefore this is what the LORD God of Hosts says: "Because you have spoken this word, I will make My words a fire in your mouth and this people the wood it consumes."

[15] "Behold, I am bringing a distant nation against you, O house of Israel," declares the LORD. "It is an established nation, an ancient nation, a nation whose language you do not know and whose speech you do not understand." [16] Their quivers are like open graves; they are all mighty men. [17] "They will devour your harvest and food; they will consume your sons and daughters; they will eat up your flocks and herds; they will feed on your vines and fig trees. With the sword they will destroy the fortified cities in which you trust." [18] "Yet even in those days," declares the LORD, "I will not make a full end of you." [19] "And when the people ask, 'For what offense has the LORD our God done all these things to us?' You are to tell them, 'Just as you have forsaken Me and served foreign gods in your land, so will you serve foreigners in a land that is not your own.'"

[20] Declare this in the house of Jacob and proclaim it in Judah: [21] "Hear this, O foolish and senseless people, who have eyes but do not see, who have ears but do not hear." [22] "Do you not fear Me?" declares the LORD. "Do you not tremble before Me, the One who set the sand as the boundary for the sea, an enduring barrier it cannot cross? The waves surge, but they cannot prevail. They roar but cannot cross it." [23] But these people have stubborn and rebellious hearts. They have turned aside and gone away. [24] They have not said in their hearts, 'Let us fear the LORD our God, who gives the rains, both autumn and spring, in season, who keeps for us the appointed weeks of harvest.' [25] Your iniquities have diverted these from you; your sins have deprived you of My bounty. [26] For among My people are wicked men; they watch like fowlers lying in wait; they set a trap to catch men. [27] Like cages full of birds, so their houses are full of deceit. Therefore they have become powerful and rich. [28] They have grown fat and sleek, and have excelled in the deeds of the wicked. They have not taken up the cause of the fatherless, that they might prosper; nor have they defended the rights of the needy. [29] "Should I not punish them for these things?" declares the LORD. "Should I not avenge Myself on such a nation as this?" [30] A horrible and shocking thing has happened in the land. [31] The prophets prophesy falsely, and the priests rule by their own authority. My people love it so, but what will you do in the end?

6 "Run for cover, O sons of Benjamin; flee from Jerusalem! Sound the ram's horn in Tekoa; send up a signal over Beth-haccherem, for disaster looms from the north, even great destruction." [2] Though she is beautiful and delicate, I will destroy the Daughter of Zion. [3] Shepherds and their flocks will come against her; they will pitch their tents all around her, each tending his own portion: [4] 'Prepare for battle against her; rise up, let us attack at noon. Woe to us, for the daylight is fading; the evening shadows grow long.' [5] "Rise up, let us attack by night and destroy her fortresses!'" [6] For this is what the LORD of Hosts says: "Cut down the trees and raise a siege ramp against Jerusalem. This city must be punished; there is nothing but oppression in her midst." [7] As a well gushes its water, so she pours out her evil. Violence and destruction resound in her; sickness and wounds are ever before Me. [8] "Be forewarned, O Jerusalem, or I will turn away from you; I will make you a desolation, a land without inhabitant." [9] This is what the LORD of Hosts says: "Glean the remnant of Israel as thoroughly as a vine. Pass your hand once more like a grape gatherer over the branches."

[10] To whom can I give this warning? Who will listen to me? Look, their ears are closed, so they cannot hear. See, the word of the LORD has become offensive to them; they find no pleasure in it. [11] But I am full of the LORD's wrath; I am tired of holding it back. "Pour it out on the children in the street, and on the young men gathered together. For both husband and wife will be captured, the old and the very old alike." [12] "Their houses will be turned over to others, their fields and wives as well, for I will stretch out My hand against the inhabitants of the land," declares the LORD. [13] "For from the least of them to the greatest, all are greedy for gain; from prophet to priest, all practice deceit." [14] They dress the wound of My people with very little care, saying, 'Peace, peace,' when there is no peace at all. [15] "Are they ashamed of the abomination they have committed? No, they have no shame at all; they do not even know how to blush. So they will fall among the fallen; when I punish them, they will collapse," says the LORD.

[16] This is what the LORD says: "Stand at the crossroads and look. Ask for the ancient paths: 'Where is the good way?' Then walk in it, and you will find rest for your souls. But they said, 'We will not walk in it!'" [17] I appointed watchmen over you and said, 'Listen for the sound of the ram's horn.' But they answered, 'We will not listen!' [18] Therefore hear, O nations, and learn, O congregations, what will happen to them. [19] Hear, O earth! I am bringing disaster on this people, the fruit of their own schemes, because they have paid no attention to My word and have rejected My instruction.

[20] "What use to Me is frankincense from Sheba or sweet cane from a distant land? Your burnt offerings are not acceptable; your sacrifices do not please Me." [21] Therefore this is what the LORD says: "I will lay stumbling blocks before this people; fathers and sons alike will be staggered; friends and neighbors

will perish." [22] This is what the LORD says: "Behold, an army is coming from the land of the north; a great nation is stirred up from the ends of the earth." [23] "They grasp the bow and spear; they are cruel and merciless. Their voice roars like the sea, and they ride upon horses, lined up like men in formation against you, O Daughter of Zion." [24] We have heard the report; our hands hang limp. Anguish has gripped us, pain like that of a woman in labor. [25] Do not go out to the fields; do not walk the road. For the enemy has a sword; terror is on every side. [26] O daughter of my people, dress yourselves in sackcloth and roll in ashes. Mourn with bitter wailing, as you would for an only son, for suddenly the destroyer will come upon us. [27] "I have appointed you to examine My people like ore, so you may know and try their ways." [28] All are hardened rebels, walking around as slanderers. They are bronze and iron; all of them are corrupt. [29] The bellows blow fiercely, blasting away the lead with fire. The refining proceeds in vain, for the wicked are not purged. [30] "They are called rejected silver, because the LORD has rejected them."

7 This is the word that came to Jeremiah from the LORD, saying, [2] "Stand in the gate of the house of the LORD and proclaim this message: Hear the word of the LORD, all you people of Judah who enter through these gates to worship the LORD." [3] Thus says the LORD of Hosts, the God of Israel: Correct your ways and deeds, and I will let you live in this place. [4] Do not trust in deceptive words, chanting: 'This is the temple of the LORD, the temple of the LORD, the temple of the LORD.' [5] For if you really correct your ways and deeds, if you act justly toward one another, [6] if you no longer oppress the foreigner and the fatherless and the widow, and if you no longer shed innocent blood in this place or follow other gods to your own harm, [7] then I will let you live in this place, in the land that I gave to your fathers forever and ever. [8] But look, you keep trusting in deceptive words to no avail. [9] Will you steal and murder, commit adultery and perjury, burn incense to Baal, and follow other gods that you have not known, [10] and then come and stand before Me in this house, which bears My Name, and say, 'We are delivered, so we can continue with all these abominations'?

[11] Has this house, which bears My Name, become a den of robbers in your sight? Yes, I too have seen it, declares the LORD. [12] But go now to the place in Shiloh where I first made a dwelling for My Name, and see what I did to it because of the wickedness of My people Israel. [13] And now, because you have done all these things, declares the LORD, and because I have spoken to you again and again but you would not listen, and I have called to you but you would not answer, [14] therefore what I did to Shiloh I will now do to the house that bears My Name, the house in which you trust, the place that I gave to you and your fathers. [15] And I will cast you out of My presence, just as I have cast out all your brothers, all the descendants of Ephraim. [16] As for you, do not pray for these people, do not offer a plea or petition on their behalf, and do not beg Me, for I will not listen to you. [17] Do you not see what they are doing in the cities of Judah and in the streets of Jerusalem? [18] The sons gather wood, the fathers light the fire, and the women knead the dough to make cakes for the Queen of Heaven; they pour out drink offerings to other gods to provoke Me to anger. [19] But am I the One they are provoking? declares the LORD. Is it not themselves they spite, to their own shame? [20] Therefore this is what the Lord GOD says: Behold, My anger and My fury will be poured out on this place, on man and beast, on the trees of the field and the produce of the land, and it will burn and not be extinguished.

[21] This is what the LORD of Hosts, the God of Israel, says: Add your burnt offerings to your other sacrifices and eat the meat yourselves!

[22] For when I brought your fathers out of the land of Egypt, I did not merely command them about burnt offerings and sacrifices, [23] but this is what I commanded them: Obey Me, and I will be your God, and you will be My people. You must walk in all the ways I have commanded you, so that it may go well with you. [24] Yet they did not listen or incline their ear, but they followed the stubborn inclinations of their own evil hearts. They went backward and not forward. [25] From the day your fathers came out of the land of Egypt until this day, I have sent you all My servants the prophets again and again. [26] Yet they would not listen to Me or incline their ear, but they stiffened their necks and did more evil than their fathers. [27] When you tell them all these things, they will not listen to you. When you call to them, they will not answer. [28] Therefore you must say to them, 'This is the nation that would not listen to the voice of the LORD their God and would not receive correction. Truth has perished; it has disappeared from their lips.' [29] Cut off your hair and throw it away. Raise up a lamentation on the barren heights, for the LORD has rejected and forsaken the generation of His wrath.' [30] For the people of Judah have done evil in My sight, declares the LORD. They have set up their abominations in the house that bears My Name, and so have defiled it. [31] They have built the high places of Topheth in the Valley of Hinnom so they could burn their sons and daughters in the fire —something I never commanded, nor did it even enter My mind. [32] So behold, the days are coming, declares the LORD, when this place will no longer be called Topheth and the Valley of Hinnom, but the Valley of Slaughter. For they will bury the dead in Topheth until there is no more room. [33] The corpses of this people will become food for the birds of the air and the beasts of the earth, and there will be no one to scare them away. [34] "I will remove from the cities of Judah and the streets of Jerusalem the sounds of joy and gladness and the voices of the bride and bridegroom, for the land will become a wasteland."

8 "At that time," declares the LORD, "the bones of the kings of Judah, the bones of the officials, the bones of the priests, the bones of the prophets, and the bones of the people of Jerusalem will be removed from their graves." [2] They will be exposed to the sun and moon, and to all the host of heaven which they have loved, served, followed, consulted, and worshiped. Their bones will not be gathered up or buried, but will become like dung lying on the ground. [3] "And wherever I have banished them, the remnant of this evil family will choose death over life," declares the LORD of Hosts. [4] So you are to tell them this is what the LORD says: "Do men fall and not get up again? Does one turn away and not return?" [5] Why then have these people turned away? Why does Jerusalem always turn away? They cling to deceit; they refuse to return. [6] I have listened and heard; they do not speak what is right. No one repents of his wickedness, asking, 'What have I done?' Everyone has pursued his own course like a horse charging into battle.

[7] Even the stork in the sky knows her appointed seasons. The turtledove, the swift, and the thrush keep their time of migration, but My people do not know the requirements of the LORD. [8] How can you say, 'We are wise, and the Law of the LORD is with us,' when in fact the lying pen of the scribes has produced a deception? [9] The wise will be put to shame; they will be dismayed and trapped. Since they have rejected the word of the LORD, what wisdom do they really have?

[10] Therefore I will give their wives to other men and their fields to new owners. For from the least of them to the greatest, all are greedy for gain; from prophet to priest, all practice deceit. [11] They dress the wound of the daughter of My people with very little care, saying, 'Peace, peace,' when there is no peace at all. [12] Are they ashamed of the abomination they have committed? No, they have no shame at all; they do not even know how to blush. So they will fall among the fallen; when I punish them, they will collapse, says the LORD. [13] "I will take away their harvest, declares the LORD. There will be no grapes on the vine, nor figs on the tree, and even the leaf will wither. Whatever I have given them will be lost to them."

[14] Why are we just sitting here? Gather together, let us flee to the fortified cities and perish there, for the LORD our God has doomed us. He has given us poisoned water to drink, because we have sinned against the LORD. [15] We hoped for peace, but no good has come, for a time of healing, but there was only terror. [16] The snorting of enemy horses is heard from Dan. At the sound of the neighing of mighty steeds, the whole land quakes. They come to devour the land and everything in it, the city and all who dwell in it. [17] "For behold, I will send snakes among you, vipers that cannot be charmed, and they will bite you," declares the LORD. [18] My sorrow is beyond healing; my heart is faint within me. [19] Listen to the cry of the daughter of my people from a land far away: "Is the LORD no longer in Zion? Is her King no longer there?" "Why have they provoked Me to anger with their carved images, with their worthless foreign idols?" [20] "The harvest has passed, the summer has ended, but we have not been saved." [21] For the brokenness of the daughter of my people I am crushed. I mourn; horror has gripped me. [22] Is there no balm in Gilead? Is no physician there? Why then has the health of the daughter of my people not been restored?

9 Oh, that my head were a spring of water, and my eyes a fountain of tears! I would weep day and night over the slain daughter of my people. [2] If only I had a traveler's lodge in the wilderness, I would abandon my people and depart from them, for they are all adulterers, a crowd of faithless people. [3] "They bend their tongues like bows; lies prevail over truth in the land. For they proceed from evil to evil, and they do not take Me into account," declares the LORD. [4] "Let everyone guard against his neighbor; do not trust any brother, for every brother deals craftily, and every friend spreads slander." [5] Each one betrays his friend; no one tells the truth. They have taught their tongues to lie; they wear themselves out committing iniquity. [6] "You dwell in the midst of deception; in their deceit they refuse to know Me," declares the LORD. [7] Therefore this is what the LORD of Hosts says: "Behold, I will refine them and test them, for what else can I do because of the daughter of My people?"

[8] Their tongues are deadly arrows; they speak deception. With his mouth a man speaks peace to his neighbor, but in his heart he sets a trap for him. [9] "Should I not punish them for these things? declares the LORD. Should I not avenge Myself on such a nation as this?" [10] I will take up a weeping and wailing for the mountains, a dirge over the wilderness pasture, for they have been scorched so no one passes through, and the lowing of cattle is not heard. Both the birds of the air and the beasts have fled; they have gone away. [11] "And I will make Jerusalem a heap of rubble, a haunt for jackals; and I will make the cities of Judah a desolation, without inhabitant." [12] Who is the man wise enough to understand this? To whom has the mouth of the LORD spoken, that he may explain it? Why is the land destroyed and scorched like a desert, so no one can pass through it?

[13] And the LORD answered, "It is because they have forsaken My law, which I set before them; they have not walked in it or obeyed My voice." [14] "Instead, they have followed the stubbornness of their hearts and gone after the Baals, as their fathers taught them." [15] Therefore this is what the LORD of Hosts, the God of Israel, says: "Behold, I will feed this people wormwood and give them poisoned water to drink." [16] "I will scatter them among the nations that neither they nor their fathers have known, and I will send a sword after them until I have finished them off."

[17] This is what the LORD of Hosts says: "Take note, and summon the wailing women; send for the most skillful among them." [18] Let them come quickly and take up a lament over us, that our eyes may overflow with tears, and our eyelids

may gush with water. [19] "For the sound of wailing is heard from Zion: 'How devastated we are! How great is our shame! For we have abandoned the land because our dwellings have been torn down.'" [20] Now, O women, hear the word of the LORD. Open your ears to the word of His mouth. Teach your daughters to wail, and one another to lament. [21] For death has climbed in through our windows; it has entered our fortresses to cut off the children from the streets, the young men from the town squares. [22] Declare that this is what the LORD says: "The corpses of men will fall like dung upon the open field, like newly cut grain behind the reaper, with no one to gather it." [23] This is what the LORD says: "Let not the wise man boast in his wisdom, nor the strong man in his strength, nor the wealthy man in his riches." [24] "But let him who boasts boast in this, that he understands and knows Me, that I am the LORD, who exercises loving devotion, justice and righteousness on the earth— for I delight in these things," declares the LORD. [25] "Behold, the days are coming," declares the LORD, "when I will punish all who are circumcised yet uncircumcised:" [26] "Egypt, Judah, Edom, Ammon, Moab, and all the inhabitants of the desert who clip the hair of their temples. For all these nations are uncircumcised, and the whole house of Israel is uncircumcised in heart."

10 Hear the word that the LORD speaks to you, O house of Israel. [2] This is what the LORD says: "Do not learn the ways of the nations or be terrified by the signs in the heavens, though the nations themselves are terrified by them." [3] For the customs of the peoples are worthless; they cut down a tree from the forest; it is shaped with a chisel by the hands of a craftsman. [4] They adorn it with silver and gold and fasten it with hammer and nails, so that it will not totter. [5] "Like scarecrows in a cucumber patch, their idols cannot speak. They must be carried because they cannot walk. Do not fear them, for they can do no harm, and neither can they do any good." [6] There is none like You, O LORD. You are great, and Your name is mighty in power. [7] Who would not fear You, O King of nations? This is Your due. For among all the wise men of the nations, and in all their kingdoms, there is none like You.

[8] But they are altogether senseless and foolish, instructed by worthless idols made of wood! [9] Hammered silver is brought from Tarshish, and gold from Uphaz— the work of a craftsman from the hands of a goldsmith. Their clothes are blue and purple, all fashioned by skilled workers. [10] But the LORD is the true God; He is the living God and eternal King. The earth quakes at His wrath, and the nations cannot endure His indignation. [11] Thus you are to tell them: "These gods, who have made neither the heavens nor the earth, will perish from this earth and from under these heavens."

[12] The LORD made the earth by His power; He established the world by His wisdom and stretched out the heavens by His understanding. [13] When He thunders, the waters in the heavens roar; He causes the clouds to rise from the ends of the earth. He generates the lightning with the rain and brings forth the wind from His storehouses. [14] Every man is senseless and devoid of knowledge; every goldsmith is put to shame by his idols. For his molten images are a fraud, and there is no breath in them. [15] They are worthless, a work to be mocked. In the time of their punishment they will perish.

[16] The Portion of Jacob is not like these, for He is the Maker of all things, and Israel is the tribe of His inheritance— the LORD of Hosts is His name. [17] Gather up your belongings from this land, you who live under siege. [18] For this is what the LORD says: "Behold, at this time I will sling out the inhabitants of the land and bring distress upon them so that they may be captured." [19] Woe to me because of my brokenness; my wound is grievous! But I said, "This is truly my sickness, and I must bear it." [20] My tent is destroyed, and all its ropes are snapped. My sons have departed from me and are no more. I have no one left to pitch my tent or set up my curtains. [21] For the shepherds have become senseless; they do not seek the LORD. Therefore they have not prospered, and all their flock is scattered. [22] Listen! The sound of a report is coming— a great commotion from the land to the north. The cities of Judah will be made a desolation, a haunt for jackals. [23] I know, O LORD, that a man's way is not his own; no one who walks directs his own steps. [24] Correct me, O LORD, but only with justice— not in Your anger, or You will bring me to nothing. [25] Pour out Your wrath on the nations that do not acknowledge You, and on the families that do not call on Your name. For they have devoured Jacob; they have consumed him and finished him off; they have devastated his homeland.

11 This is the word that came to Jeremiah from the LORD: [2] "Listen to the words of this covenant and tell them to the men of Judah and the residents of Jerusalem." [3] You must tell them that this is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says: Cursed is the man who does not obey the words of this covenant, [4] which I commanded your forefathers when I brought them out of the land of Egypt, out of the iron furnace, saying, 'Obey Me, and do everything I command you, and you will be My people, and I will be your God.' [5] "This was in order to establish the oath I swore to your forefathers, to give them a land flowing with milk and honey, as it is to this day." "Amen, LORD," I answered. [6] Then the LORD said to me, "Proclaim all these words in the cities of Judah and in the streets of Jerusalem, saying: Hear the words of this covenant and carry them out."

[7] For from the time I brought your fathers out of the land of Egypt until today, I strongly warned them again and again, saying, 'Obey My voice.' [8] "Yet they would not obey or incline their ears, but each one followed the stubbornness of his evil heart. So I brought on them all the curses of this covenant I had commanded them to follow but they did not keep." [9] And the LORD told me, "There is a conspiracy among the men of Judah and the residents of Jerusalem." [10] They have returned to the sins of their forefathers who refused to obey My words. They have followed other gods to serve them. The house of Israel and the house of Judah have broken the covenant I made with their fathers.

[11] Therefore this is what the LORD says: 'I am about to bring upon them a disaster that they cannot escape. They will cry out to Me, but I will not listen to them.' [12] Then the cities of Judah and the residents of Jerusalem will go and cry out to the gods to which they have been burning incense, but these gods certainly will not save them in their time of disaster. [13] Your gods are indeed as numerous as your cities, O Judah; the altars of shame you have set up—the altars to burn incense to Baal—are as many as the streets of Jerusalem.' [14] As for you, do not pray for these people. Do not raise up a cry or a prayer on their behalf, for I will not be listening when they call out to Me in their time of disaster.

[15] What right has My beloved in My house, having carried out so many evil schemes? Can consecrated meat avert your doom, so that you can rejoice? [16] The LORD once called you a flourishing olive tree, beautiful with well-formed fruit. But with a mighty roar He will set it on fire, and its branches will be consumed. [17] "The LORD of Hosts, who planted you, has decreed disaster against you on account of the evil that the house of Israel and the house of Judah have brought upon themselves, provoking Me to anger by burning incense to Baal." [18] And the LORD informed me, so I knew. Then You showed me their deeds. [19] For I was like a gentle lamb led to slaughter; I did not know that they had plotted against me: "Let us destroy the tree with its fruit; let us cut him off from the land of the living, that his name may be remembered no more." [20] O LORD of Hosts, who judges righteously, who examines the heart and mind, let me see Your vengeance upon them, for to You I have committed my cause. [21] Therefore this is what the LORD says concerning the people of Anathoth who are seeking your life and saying, "You must not prophesy in the name of the LORD, or you will die by our hand." [22] So this is what the LORD of Hosts says: "I will punish them. Their young men will die by the sword, their sons and daughters by famine." [23] "There will be no remnant, for I will bring disaster on the people of Anathoth in the year of their punishment."

12 Righteous are You, O LORD, when I plead before You. Yet about Your judgments I wish to contend with You: Why does the way of the wicked prosper? Why do all the faithless live at ease? [2] You planted them, and they have taken root. They have grown and produced fruit. You are ever on their lips, but far from their hearts. [3] But You know me, O LORD; You see me and test my heart toward You. Drag away the wicked like sheep to the slaughter and set them apart for the day of carnage. [4] How long will the land mourn and the grass of every field be withered? Because of the evil of its residents, the animals and birds have been swept away, for the people have said, "He cannot see what our end will be." [5] "If you have raced with men on foot and they have worn you out, how can you compete with horses? If you stumble in a peaceful land, how will you do in the thickets of the Jordan?" [6] Even your brothers— your own father's household — even they have betrayed you; even they have cried aloud against you. Do not trust them, though they speak well of you. [7] I have forsaken My house; I have abandoned My inheritance. I have given the love of My life into the hands of her enemies.

[8] My inheritance has become to Me like a lion in the forest. She has roared against Me; therefore I hate her. [9] Is not My inheritance to Me like a speckled bird of prey with other birds of prey circling against her? Go, gather all the beasts of the field; bring them to devour her. [10] Many shepherds have destroyed My vineyard; they have trampled My plot of ground. They have turned My pleasant field into a desolate wasteland. [11] They have made it a desolation; desolate before Me, it mourns. All the land is laid waste, but no man takes it to heart. [12] Over all the barren heights in the wilderness the destroyers have come, for the sword of the LORD devours from one end of the earth to the other. No flesh has peace. [13] "They have sown wheat but harvested thorns. They have exhausted themselves to no avail. Bear the shame of your harvest because of the fierce anger of the LORD." [14] This is what the LORD says: "As for all My evil neighbors who attack the inheritance that I bequeathed to My people Israel, I am about to uproot them from their land, and I will uproot the house of Judah from among them." [15] But after I have uprooted them, I will once again have compassion on them and return each one to his inheritance and to his land. [16] And if they will diligently learn the ways of My people and swear by My name, saying, 'As surely as the LORD lives'—just as they once taught My people to swear by Baal—then they will be established among My people. [17] "But if they will not obey, then I will uproot that nation; I will uproot it and destroy it, declares the LORD."

13 This is what the LORD said to me: "Go and buy yourself a linen loincloth and put it around your waist, but do not let it touch water." [2] So I bought a loincloth as the LORD had instructed me, and I put it around my waist. [3] Then the word of the LORD came to me a second time: [4] "Take the loincloth that you bought and are wearing, and go at once to Perath and hide it there in a crevice of the rocks." [5] So I went and hid it at Perath, as the LORD had commanded me. [6] Many days later the LORD said to me, "Arise, go to Perath, and get the loincloth that I commanded you to hide there." [7] So I went to Perath and dug up the loincloth, and I took it from the place where I had hidden it. But now it was

ruined—of no use at all. [8] Then the word of the LORD came to me: [9] "This is what the LORD says: In the same way I will ruin the pride of Judah and the great pride of Jerusalem." [10] These evil people, who refuse to listen to My words, who follow the stubbornness of their own hearts, and who go after other gods to serve and worship them, they will be like this loincloth—of no use at all. [11] For just as a loincloth clings to a man's waist, so I have made the whole house of Israel and the whole house of Judah cling to Me, declares the LORD, so that they might be My people for My renown and praise and glory. But they did not listen. [12] Therefore you are to tell them that this is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says: 'Every wineskin shall be filled with wine.' And when they reply, 'Don't we surely know that every wineskin should be filled with wine?'

[13] then you are to tell them that this is what the LORD says: 'I am going to fill with drunkenness all who live in this land—the kings who sit on David's throne, the priests, the prophets, and all the people of Jerusalem.' [14] "I will smash them against one another, fathers and sons alike, declares the LORD. I will allow no mercy or pity or compassion to keep Me from destroying them.'" [15] Listen and give heed. Do not be arrogant, for the LORD has spoken. [16] Give glory to the LORD your God before He brings darkness, before your feet stumble on the dusky mountains. You wait for light, but He turns it into deep gloom and thick darkness. [17] But if you do not listen, I will weep in secret because of your pride. My eyes will overflow with tears, because the LORD's flock has been taken captive.

[18] Say to the king and to the queen mother: "Take a lowly seat, for your glorious crowns have fallen from your heads." [19] The cities of the Negev have been shut tight, and no one can open them. All Judah has been carried into exile, wholly taken captive. [20] Lift up your eyes and see those coming from the north. Where is the flock entrusted to you, the sheep that were your pride? [21] What will you say when He sets over you close allies whom you yourself trained? Will not pangs of anguish grip you, as they do a woman in labor? [22] And if you ask yourself, "Why has this happened to me?" It is because of the magnitude of your iniquity that your skirts have been stripped off and your body has been exposed. [23] Can the Ethiopian change his skin, or the leopard his spots? Neither are you able to do good— you who are accustomed to doing evil. [24] "I will scatter you like chaff driven by the desert wind." [25] "This is your lot, the portion I have measured to you," declares the LORD, "because you have forgotten Me and trusted in falsehood." [26] So I will pull your skirts up over your face, that your shame may be seen. [27] "Your adulteries and lustful neighings, your shameless prostitution on the hills and in the fields— I have seen your detestable acts. Woe to you, O Jerusalem! How long will you remain unclean?"

14 This is the word of the LORD that came to Jeremiah concerning the drought: [2] "Judah mourns and her gates languish. Her people wail for the land, and a cry goes up from Jerusalem." [3] The nobles send their servants for water; they go to the cisterns, but find no water; their jars return empty. They are ashamed and humiliated; they cover their heads. [4] The ground is cracked because no rain has fallen on the land. The farmers are ashamed; they cover their heads. [5] Even the doe in the field deserts her newborn fawn because there is no grass. [6] "Wild donkeys stand on barren heights; they pant for air like jackals; their eyes fail for lack of pasture."

[7] Although our iniquities testify against us, O LORD, act for the sake of Your name. Indeed, our rebellions are many; we have sinned against You. [8] O Hope of Israel, its Savior in times of distress, why are You like a stranger in the land, like a traveler who stays but a night? [9] Why are You like a man taken by surprise, like a warrior powerless to save? Yet You are among us, O LORD, and we are called by Your name. Do not forsake us!

[10] This is what the LORD says about this people: "Truly they love to wander; they have not restrained their feet. So the LORD does not accept them; He will now remember their guilt and call their sins to account." [11] Then the LORD said to me, "Do not pray for the well-being of this people." [12] "Although they may fast, I will not listen to their cry; although they may offer burnt offerings and grain offerings, I will not accept them. Instead, I will finish them off by sword and famine and plague." [13] "Ah, Lord GOD!" I replied, "Look, the prophets are telling them, 'You will not see the sword or suffer famine, but I will give you lasting peace in this place.'"

[14] "The prophets are prophesying lies in My name," replied the LORD. "I did not send them or appoint them or speak to them. They are prophesying to you a false vision, a worthless divination, the futility and delusion of their own minds." [15] Therefore this is what the LORD says about the prophets who prophesy in My name: I did not send them, yet they say, 'No sword or famine will touch this land.' By sword and famine these very prophets will meet their end! [16] And the people to whom they prophesy will be thrown into the streets of Jerusalem because of famine and sword. There will be no one to bury them or their wives, their sons or their daughters. I will pour out their own evil upon them. [17] You are to speak this word to them: 'My eyes overflow with tears; day and night they do not cease, for the virgin daughter of my people has been shattered by a crushing blow, a severely grievous wound.' [18] "If I go out to the country, I see those slain by the sword; if I enter the city, I see those ravaged by famine! For both prophet and priest travel to a land they do not know.'" [19] Have You rejected Judah completely? Do You despise Zion? Why have You stricken us so that we are beyond healing? We hoped for peace, but no good has come, and for the time of healing, but there was only terror. [20] We acknowledge our wickedness, O LORD, the guilt of our fathers; indeed, we have sinned against You. [21] For the sake of Your name do not despise us; do not disgrace Your glorious throne. Remember Your covenant with us; do not break it. [22] Can the worthless idols of the nations bring rain? Do the skies alone send showers? Is this not by You, O LORD our God? So we put our hope in You, for You have done all these things.

15 Then the LORD said to me: "Even if Moses and Samuel should stand before Me, My heart would not go out to this people. Send them from My presence, and let them go." [2] If they ask you, 'Where shall we go?' you are to tell them that this is what the LORD says: 'Those destined for death, to death; those destined for the sword, to the sword; those destined for famine, to famine; and those destined for captivity, to captivity.' [3] I will appoint over them four kinds of destroyers, declares the LORD: the sword to kill, the dogs to drag away, and the birds of the air and beasts of the earth to devour and destroy. [4] I will make them a horror to all the kingdoms of the earth because of what Manasseh son of Hezekiah king of Judah did in Jerusalem. [5] Who will have pity on you, O Jerusalem? Who will mourn for you? Who will turn aside to ask about your welfare? [6] You have forsaken Me, declares the LORD. You have turned your back. So I will stretch out My hand against you and I will destroy you; I am weary of showing compassion.

[7] I will scatter them with a winnowing fork at the gates of the land. I will bereave and destroy My people who have not turned from their ways. [8] I will make their widows more numerous than the sand of the sea. I will bring a destroyer at noon against the mothers of young men. I will suddenly bring upon them anguish and dismay. [9] "The mother of seven will grow faint; she will breathe her last breath. Her sun will set while it is still day; she will be disgraced and humiliated. And the rest I will put to the sword in the presence of their enemies," declares the LORD.

[10] Woe to me, my mother, that you have borne me, a man of strife and conflict in all the land. I have neither lent nor borrowed, yet everyone curses me. [11] The LORD said: "Surely I will deliver you for a good purpose; surely I will intercede with your enemy in your time of trouble, in your time of distress." [12] Can anyone smash iron— iron from the north—or bronze? [13] Your wealth and your treasures I will give up as plunder, without charge for all your sins within all your borders.

[14] "Then I will enslave you to your enemies in a land you do not know, for My anger will kindle a fire that will burn against you." [15] You understand, O LORD; remember me and attend to me. Avenge me against my persecutors. In Your patience, do not take me away. Know that I endure reproach for Your honor. [16] Your words were found, and I ate them. Your words became my joy and my heart's delight. For I bear Your name, O LORD God of Hosts. [17] I never sat with the band of revelers, nor did I celebrate with them. Because Your hand was on me, I sat alone, for You have filled me with indignation. [18] Why is my pain unending, and my wound incurable, refusing to be healed? You have indeed become like a mirage to me— water that is not there. [19] Therefore this is what the LORD says: "If you return, I will restore you; you will stand in My presence. And if you speak words that are noble instead of worthless, you will be My spokesman. It is they who must turn to you, but you must not turn to them." [20] Then I will make you a wall to this people, a fortified wall of bronze; they will fight against you but will not overcome you, for I am with you to save and deliver you, declares the LORD. [21] "I will deliver you from the hand of the wicked and redeem you from the grasp of the ruthless."

16 Then the word of the LORD came to me, saying, [2] "You must not marry or have sons or daughters in this place." [3] For this is what the LORD says concerning the sons and daughters born in this place, and the mothers who bore them, and the fathers who fathered them in this land: [4] "They will die from deadly diseases. They will not be mourned or buried, but will lie like dung on the ground. They will be finished off by sword and famine, and their corpses will become food for the birds of the air and beasts of the earth." [5] Indeed, this is what the LORD says: "Do not enter a house where there is a funeral meal. Do not go to mourn or show sympathy, for I have removed from this people My peace, My loving devotion, and My compassion," declares the LORD. [6] "Both great and small will die in this land. They will not be buried or mourned, nor will anyone cut himself or shave his head for them."

[7] No food will be offered to comfort those who mourn the dead; not even a cup of consolation will be given for the loss of a father or mother. [8] You must not enter a house where there is feasting and sit down with them to eat and drink. [9] For this is what the LORD of Hosts, the God of Israel, says: I am going to remove from this place, before your very eyes and in your days, the sounds of joy and gladness, the voices of the bride and bridegroom. [10] When you tell these people all these things, they will ask you, 'Why has the LORD pronounced all this great disaster against us? What is our guilt? What is the sin that we have committed against the LORD our God?'

[11] Then you are to answer them: 'It is because your fathers have forsaken Me, declares the LORD, and followed other gods, and served and worshiped them. They abandoned Me and did not keep My instruction.' [12] And you have done more evil than your fathers. See how each of you follows the stubbornness of his evil heart instead of obeying Me. [13] So I will cast you out of this land into a land that neither you nor your fathers have known. There you will serve other gods day and night, for I will show you no favor.'

[14] Yet behold, the days are coming, declares the LORD, when they will no
longer say, 'As surely as the LORD lives, who brought the Israelites up out of
the land of Egypt.' [15] Instead they will say, 'As surely as the LORD lives, who
brought the Israelites up out of the land of the north and all the other lands to
which He had banished them.' For I will return them to their land that I gave
to their forefathers. [16] But for now I will send for many fishermen, declares the
LORD, and they will catch them. After that I will send for many hunters, and
they will hunt them down on every mountain and hill, even from the clefts of
the rocks. [17] For My eyes are on all their ways. They are not hidden from My
face, and their guilt is not concealed from My eyes. [18] "And I will first repay
them double their iniquity and their sin, because they have defiled My land with
the carcasses of their detestable idols, and they have filled My inheritance with
their abominations." [19] O LORD, my strength and my fortress, my refuge in the
day of distress, the nations will come to You from the ends of the earth, and they
will say, "Our fathers inherited nothing but lies, worthless idols of no benefit
at all." [20] "Can man make gods for himself? Such are not gods!" [21] "Therefore
behold, I will inform them, and this time I will make them know My power and
My might; then they will know that My name is the LORD."

17 "The sin of Judah is written with an iron stylus, engraved with a diamond
point on the tablets of their hearts and on the horns of their altars." [2] Even their
children remember their altars and Asherah poles by the green trees and on the
high hills. [3] O My mountain in the countryside, I will give over your wealth and
all your treasures as plunder, because of the sin of your high places, within all
your borders. [4] "And you yourself will relinquish the inheritance that I gave you.
I will enslave you to your enemies in a land that you do not know, for you have
kindled My anger; it will burn forever." [5] This is what the LORD says: "Cursed
is the man who trusts in mankind, who makes the flesh his strength and turns
his heart from the LORD." [6] He will be like a shrub in the desert; he will not
see when prosperity comes. He will dwell in the parched places of the desert, in
a salt land where no one lives. [7] But blessed is the man who trusts in the LORD,
whose confidence is in Him. [8] He is like a tree planted by the waters that sends
out its roots toward the stream. It does not fear when the heat comes, and its
leaves are always green. It does not worry in a year of drought, nor does it cease
to produce fruit.

[9] The heart is deceitful above all things and beyond cure. Who can
understand it? [10] I, the LORD, search the heart; I examine the mind to reward a
man according to his way, by what his deeds deserve. [11] "Like a partridge hatching
eggs it did not lay is the man who makes a fortune unjustly. In the middle of his
days his riches will desert him, and in the end he will be the fool." [12] A glorious
throne, exalted from the beginning, is the place of our sanctuary. [13] O LORD,
the hope of Israel, all who abandon You will be put to shame. All who turn away
will be written in the dust, for they have abandoned the LORD, the fountain of
living water. [14] Heal me, O LORD, and I will be healed; save me, and I will be
saved, for You are my praise.

[15] Behold, they keep saying to me, "Where is the word of the LORD? Let it
come now!" [16] But I have not run away from being Your shepherd; I have not
desired the day of despair. You know that the utterance of my lips was spoken
in Your presence. [17] Do not become a terror to me; You are my refuge in the day
of disaster.

[18] Let my persecutors be put to shame, but do not let me be put to shame. Let
them be terrified, but do not let me be terrified. Bring upon them the day of
disaster and shatter them with double destruction. [19] This is what the LORD
said to me: "Go and stand at the gate of the people, through which the kings
of Judah go in and out; and stand at all the other gates of Jerusalem." [20] Say to
them, 'Hear the word of the LORD, O kings of Judah, all people of Judah and
Jerusalem who enter through these gates.' [21] This is what the LORD says: Take
heed for yourselves; do not carry a load or bring it through the gates of Jerusalem
on the Sabbath day. [22] You must not carry a load out of your houses or do any
work on the Sabbath day, but you must keep the Sabbath day holy, just as I
commanded your forefathers. [23] Yet they would not listen or incline their ear,
but they stiffened their necks and would not listen or receive My discipline. [24] If,
however, you listen carefully to Me, says the LORD, and bring no load through
the gates of this city on the Sabbath day, and keep the Sabbath day holy, and
do no work on it, [25] then kings and princes will enter through the gates of this
city. They will sit on the throne of David, riding in chariots and on horses with
their officials, along with the men of Judah and the residents of Jerusalem, and
this city will be inhabited forever. [26] And people will come from the cities of
Judah and the places around Jerusalem, from the land of Benjamin, and from the
foothills, the hill country, and the Negev, bringing burnt offerings and sacrifices,
grain offerings and frankincense, and thank offerings to the house of the LORD.
[27] "But if you do not listen to Me to keep the Sabbath day holy by not carrying a
load while entering the gates of Jerusalem on the Sabbath day, then I will kindle
an unquenchable fire in its gates to consume the citadels of Jerusalem.'"

18 This is the word that came to Jeremiah from the LORD: [2] "Go down at
once to the potter's house, and there I will reveal My message to you." [3] So I went
down to the potter's house and saw him working at the wheel. [4] But the vessel
that he was shaping from the clay became flawed in his hand; so he formed it into
another vessel, as it seemed best for him to do. [5] Then the word of the LORD
came to me, saying, [6] "O house of Israel, declares the LORD, can I not treat you
as this potter treats his clay? Just like clay in the potter's hand, so are you in My
hand, O house of Israel."

[7] At any time I might announce that a nation or kingdom will be uprooted,
torn down, and destroyed. [8] But if that nation I warned turns from its evil, then
I will relent of the disaster I had planned to bring. [9] And if at another time I
announce that I will build up and establish a nation or kingdom, [10] and if it does
evil in My sight and does not listen to My voice, then I will relent of the good I
had intended for it.

[11] Now therefore, tell the men of Judah and the residents of Jerusalem that this
is what the LORD says: 'Behold, I am planning a disaster for you and devising a
plan against you. Turn now, each of you, from your evil ways, and correct your
ways and deeds.' [12] "But they will reply, 'It is hopeless. We will follow our own
plans, and each of us will act according to the stubbornness of his evil heart.'"
[13] Therefore this is what the LORD says: "Inquire among the nations: Who has
ever heard things like these? Virgin Israel has done a most terrible thing." [14] Does
the snow of Lebanon ever leave its rocky slopes? Or do its cool waters flowing
from a distance ever run dry?

[15] Yet My people have forgotten Me. They burn incense to worthless idols that
make them stumble in their ways, leaving the ancient roads to walk on rutted
bypaths instead of on the highway. [16] They have made their land a desolation, a
perpetual object of scorn; all who pass by will be appalled and shake their heads.

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